

# 1 Corinthians Part 1

## The Cross and a Divided Church

**BIG IDEA** The crucified Christ overturns worldly measures of wisdom, power, and status. Church leaders are servants, the church belongs to God, and every believer belongs to Christ.

### Purpose and outcome

By the end of the lesson, the class should be able to:

- describe how Corinth's social competition helps explain the church's attraction to impressive leaders and worldly wisdom;
- explain why the message of Christ crucified overturns human boasting and cultural measures of success;
- recognize jealousy, rivalry, and leader-centered factions as evidence of spiritual immaturity;
- describe Paul, Apollos, and other Christian leaders as servants, builders, and stewards accountable to God; and
- apply Paul's teaching without turning the lesson into a coded judgment of particular people or a defense of shallow agreement.

### Lesson at a glance

| TIME        | MOVEMENT                                                   |
|-------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| 0:00-5:00   | Opening question, prayer, and transition from Thessalonica |
| 5:00-11:00  | Corinth and the church's beginning - Acts 18               |
| 11:00-18:00 | Called by grace but divided - 1:1-17                       |
| 18:00-28:00 | The cross overturns worldly wisdom - 1:18-2:5              |
| 28:00-35:00 | God's wisdom and Corinthian immaturity - 2:6-3:4           |
| 35:00-43:00 | Servants, builders, and God's temple - 3:5-23              |
| 43:00-47:00 | Faithful stewards and cross-shaped ministry - chapter 4    |
| 47:00-50:00 | The Gospel Then and Now, homework, and prayer              |

### Before class

**Write on the board:** How do we decide whether a church or Christian leader is successful?

**Controlling question:** How does the cross change the way Christians evaluate wisdom, leadership, maturity, and success?

Mark Acts 18:1-17, 24-28; 1 Corinthians 1:10-31; 3:1-9, 16-23; and 4:1-5. Use one reader and participants' own Bibles.

**CORE READINGS** Read Acts 18:1-11; 1 Corinthians 1:10-25; 3:1-9, 16-23; and 4:1-5. Summarize the remaining material. If time becomes tight, shorten the Corinth background and chapter 2 discussion rather than omitting chapter 3.

### 1. CORE Corinth and the church's beginning

Paul probably wrote 1 Corinthians from Ephesus around AD 54-55. Corinth was a prosperous Roman colony located on the isthmus joining mainland Greece to the Peloponnese. Its ports connected trade routes toward Asia and Italy. The city was diverse, mobile, and socially competitive. Wealth, ancestry, education, patronage, and public speaking could all become claims to status.

Acts 18 describes God's ordinary and persistent work in Corinth. Claudius's expulsion of Jews from Rome brought Priscilla and Aquila into Paul's life. Paul worked beside them, reasoned in the synagogue, faced opposition, received encouragement from the Lord, and remained about eighteen months. God formed a church through displaced workers, manual labor, contested preaching, hospitality, and sustained ministry.

**HISTORICAL GUARDRAIL** Ancient jokes about 'Corinthianizing' and reports connected with the earlier Greek city should not be used to portray Roman Corinth as history's unmatched capital of vice. The letter itself gives sufficient evidence of sexual disorder, social rivalry, and status-seeking.

### Paul Apollos and Cephas

- Paul planted the church and remained in Corinth for an extended ministry.
- Apollos was an eloquent, knowledgeable Alexandrian Jew. Priscilla and Aquila instructed him more accurately in Ephesus; he then ministered fruitfully in Achaia and Corinth (Acts 18:24-28). Paul later urged him to revisit Corinth, showing that the two men were not competing for followers (1 Corinthians 16:12).
- Cephas is the Aramaic name for Peter. Scripture does not say that Peter visited Corinth. A late second-century tradition preserved by Eusebius quotes Dionysius of Corinth as connecting both Peter and Paul with Corinth. Present this as tradition, not as direct biblical evidence.
- The slogans in 1:12 may represent identifiable factions, representative expressions of party spirit, or both. Paul says in 4:6 that he has applied the matter to himself and Apollos for the Corinthians' benefit. The exact party structure remains uncertain; the sinful boasting and rivalry do not.

**DISCUSS** Do these slogans describe four exact factions, or is Paul using representative slogans to expose the church's larger habit of attaching status to leaders? What in the letter shapes your answer?

## 2. CORE Called by grace but divided

Begin with 1:1-9 before confronting the divisions. Paul calls these troubled believers sanctified in Christ, called to be holy, enriched by grace, and sustained by a faithful God. Grace does not prevent correction; it establishes the identity from which Paul corrects them.

Read 1:10-17. Chloe's household has reported quarrels. The believers use Paul, Apollos, Cephas, and even Christ as badges of superiority. Paul answers with three questions: Is Christ divided? Was Paul crucified for you? Were you baptized in Paul's name? Baptism joins believers to Christ; it cannot become a trophy proving one Christian's superiority.

**TEACHING LINE** The Corinthians used Christian leaders to build personal status. Paul returns every name, gift, baptism, and ministry to the one crucified Christ.

## 3. CORE The cross overturns worldly wisdom

Read 1:18-25 and summarize through 2:5. Crucifixion signified shame, weakness, and defeat. Yet God chose the crucified Messiah as the means of salvation. The cross therefore exposes every human attempt to reach God through status, philosophical mastery, religious performance, or rhetorical brilliance.

- Paul is not attacking intelligence, education, careful reasoning, or clear speech. Worldly wisdom becomes folly when it tries to judge or replace God's saving action in Christ.
- Jews demanded signs and Greeks sought wisdom, but Paul proclaimed Christ crucified: God's power and wisdom in a form human pride would never design.
- The Corinthians themselves were not an impressive social elite when God called them. God chose the weak and lowly so that no one could boast before him.
- Paul's refusal to depend on eloquent wisdom does not mean he preached carelessly. He refused to make performance the source of the gospel's power, because another performer could always appear more impressive.

**APOLLOS AND ELOQUENCE** Acts calls Apollos eloquent and knowledgeable. His gifts were not the problem. The Corinthians' use of different gifts as a ranking system was the problem. Paul and Apollos remained coworkers; the congregation manufactured the rivalry.

## 4. CORE God's wisdom and spiritual maturity

In 2:6-16 Paul does speak of wisdom among the mature. Christianity is not wisdom-free. God's wisdom is revealed by the Spirit and centered on what God has prepared in Christ. The 'spiritual' person is someone taught by the Spirit, not a member of a superior group possessing secret knowledge.

Read 3:1-4. The Corinthians claim maturity, but their jealousy and quarreling expose childish conduct. Paul does not ask the class to identify all the spiritual babies in the room. He gives the church a mirror: wherever rivalry and personality-centered factions govern us, we are behaving immaturely regardless of how much theology we know.

**PASTORAL WORDING** Use 'we' rather than 'you.' Ask where our loyalties and rivalries reveal a need to grow. Do not use the passage to establish a new hierarchy in which the people who recognize everyone else's immaturity become the elite.

## 5. CORE Servants builders and God's temple

Read 3:5-9. Paul and Apollos are servants through whom the Corinthians believed. One planted and another watered, but God gave the growth. Christian leaders have different assignments and real responsibility, yet neither the planter nor the waterer owns the field.

In 3:10-15 Paul changes the image from agriculture to construction. Christ is the only foundation. Christian builders must take care how they build because the coming Day will test the quality of their work. The fire is future divine evaluation, not a past church conflict and not a license to identify another person's final reward.

In 3:16-17 the congregation together is God's temple. The pronoun is plural. Dividing and damaging the church is therefore not ordinary organizational friction; it threatens something God claims as holy. Paul ends by reversing their slogans: stop boasting in leaders. Paul, Apollos, and Cephas are gifts to the church, but the church belongs to Christ.

**TEACHING LINE** Leaders do not own the church, produce its growth, or replace its foundation. They serve in God's field, build on Christ, and answer to the Lord for the quality of their work.

## 6. CORE Faithful stewards and cross-shaped ministry

Chapter 4 completes Paul's leadership portrait. Apostles and teachers are servants of Christ and stewards of what God entrusted to them. The essential requirement is faithfulness. The Lord gives the final judgment, so neither popularity nor criticism can be the final measure of ministry.

Paul's sarcasm in 4:8-13 contrasts Corinthian self-importance with apostolic weakness, suffering, and service. He then addresses them as beloved children. His authority aims at their restoration and imitation of a life shaped by Christ, not the defense of a personal brand.

**LEADER DISCERNMENT** Ask whether a leader points people to Christ, treats ministry as stewardship, credits God for growth, builds on the gospel, protects God's people, accepts accountability, and displays the self-giving pattern of the cross. Do not turn this into a public trial of a named leader.

## The Gospel Then and Now

| MOVEMENT              | CHURCH APPLICATION                                                                                                                                                              |
|-----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Church reality then   | The Corinthians ranked leaders and one another by eloquence, wisdom, status, baptism, and visible success. Their boasting produced jealousy and division.                       |
| Church temptation now | Favorite pastors, theological tribes, political identities, worship preferences, education, wealth, programs, and church size can become substitutes for identity in Christ.    |
| Gospel-shaped church  | The cross removes boasting. Leaders become servants, maturity appears in humble love, God receives credit for growth, and the church remembers that everyone belongs to Christ. |

## Discussion

1. How do we decide whether a church or Christian leader is successful? Which parts of our scorecard would Paul challenge?
2. Do the slogans in 1:12 describe four exact factions, representative slogans, or some combination? Why?
3. Why did the message of a crucified Messiah appear foolish or weak? How can the gospel still offend human pride?
4. What evidence of spiritual immaturity does Paul actually identify? How can we use his words as a mirror rather than a weapon?
5. When does healthy appreciation for a pastor or teacher become unhealthy factional loyalty?
6. How can a congregation evaluate leaders seriously while remembering that God gives the growth and Christ owns the church?
7. How can theological, political, or worship preferences become a more powerful identity than belonging to Christ?

### Scholarly notes and guardrails

- Date and place - Paul probably wrote from Ephesus during his extended ministry there, commonly dated around AD 54-55. The exact year is less important than the continuing relationship among Paul, Corinth, Ephesus, and Apollos.
- Corinth's reputation - Distinguish Roman Corinth from the Greek city destroyed in 146 BC. Avoid repeating disputed temple-prostitution claims as settled background.
- Claudius and Chrestus - Suetonius says Claudius expelled Jews from Rome amid disturbances connected with 'Chrestus.' This may reflect disputes about Christ, but the identification and circumstances remain debated.
- Peter in Corinth - Scripture supplies no direct evidence of a visit. Dionysius of Corinth, writing in the late second century and quoted by Eusebius, connects Peter and Paul with Corinth. Label it as later tradition.
- Worldly wisdom - Paul rejects wisdom that judges God and salvation by human standards. He does not endorse ignorance or careless interpretation.
- Spiritual people - Do not turn Spirit-given understanding into an elite ranking. The Corinthians' jealousy and rivalry contradict their claims to maturity.
- Fire and the Day - First Corinthians 3:10-15 concerns God's future evaluation of Christian builders and their work. It is not the church's permission to announce another person's reward or salvation.
- God's temple - In 3:16-17 the plural 'you' identifies the congregation as God's temple. Paul addresses damage to the church community; his individual-body application appears later in 6:19.

### Likely rabbit trails

Whether Peter visited Corinth; whether the four slogans map to four formal parties; the history of temple prostitution; speaking ability versus plain speech; whether 'milk' and 'solid food' identify two levels of doctrine; purgatory or rewards in 3:10-15; naming former pastors; denominational rivalries; celebrity preachers; and current political personalities. Allow honest application, but keep the class centered on Paul's remedy in Christ crucified.

### Leader preparation

Commentary and further study: Craig L. Blomberg, 1 Corinthians, NIV Application Commentary; David Prior, The Message of 1 Corinthians; Life Application Bible Commentary New Testament, 1 Corinthians; Dictionary of Paul and His Letters, articles on Corinth and 1 Corinthians.

Historical sources: Suetonius, Claudius 25.4; Eusebius, Ecclesiastical History 2.25.8, preserving Dionysius of Corinth.

Online resource: BibleProject, Book of 1 Corinthians Guide - [bibleproject.com/guides/book-of-1-corinthians/](https://bibleproject.com/guides/book-of-1-corinthians/)

ECO connection: Essential Tenet II.B, the incarnation and saving work of Jesus Christ; III.A, God's grace in Christ; and III.C, covenant life in the church. Official text: [eco-pres.org/constitution/](https://eco-pres.org/constitution/)

Before Lesson 10: Read 1 Corinthians 5-7. Mark the problems Paul addresses concerning church discipline, lawsuits, sexuality, marriage, divorce, and singleness. Notice what Paul says about belonging to Christ.